The MaBaTha has also been implicated in campaigns of intimidation against any Buddhists who dare to speak out against its agenda.[86] As with the West's assumption that Aung San Suu Kyi is beyond reproach, there is a need to challenge the view that Buddhism is inherently non-threatening. Like all religions, it can be many things to many people, and can be both tolerant and just, yet also can lend itself to extremism. In Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Thailand—where religion has become confused with ethnicity—it can be used as an excuse by extremists to justify violence against those of different faiths or ethnic groups. At the moment, there is no evidence that either the regime or the opposition is prepared to stand up to the Buddhist extremists, and both have alliances with factions within the groups of extremist monks.[87] As one Burmese journalist noted, 'the two strongest institutions in our country—the military and monk organisations—are driven by men, and promote nationalism and religion. That influences our media coverage'.[88]

The prejudice against the Rohingyas runs deep in the Buddhist community at the moment. And in a perverse example of how even the most benign religious idea can be twisted to serve an agenda of intolerance, many Buddhists justify the suffering of the Rohingyas in terms of reincarnation: if their lives are so awful now it is due to their sins in past lives.[89]

However, there is another aspect to the MaBaTha that is increasingly coming to light. The reason why a movement that did not exist before 2010 is now so influential is that it is funded and supported by the regime.[90] Monks who were arrested during the Saffron Revolution have been offered money and state patronage to join the MaBaTha and promote its core message of hatred of all Muslims.

Alternative voices in contemporary Myanmar

The material above may give the impression that anti-Rohingya racism is now the norm in Myanmar. It certainly is depressingly common. However, as in all societies, many are prepared to speak out against racism and bigotry. Similarly in Myanmar, some brave citizens have spoken out against the conflation of Buddhism with anti-Muslim prejudice.[91] Networks such as Pan Zagar have courageously taken on the extremists, explicitly rejecting